with the US. Nehru's policy called for balance: between defense and development, but also between the Soviet Union and the United States. For one, this would allow India to play one off against the other. But more than that, Nehru hoped this would allow India to maintain its freedom of action by diversifying its dependence. Diversification would allow India to reduce dependence on any one country or bloc, as well as to cope with the questionable reliability of benefactors. Finally, it was necessary to maintain the US option because of continuing Indian concerns about the Soviet Union's support of Indian communists and its lack of support for UN membership for a number of decolonized states.

Thus, to maintain balance, even as Khrushchev and Bulganin were due to visit India, Nehru extended an invitation to Eisenhower. Worried about the American reaction to the Soviet leaders' trip, he also tried to eliminate or limit their public criticism of the US.[305] Then, in March 1956, India rejected a Soviet offer of aircraft, partly because Dulles had made clear that India was unlikely to receive economic aid from the US if it was spending money on Soviet aircraft.[306]

It helped India's case that, by spring 1956, China-India comparisons were being heard on Capitol Hill. China bloc members like Judd noted the importance of not jettisoning India, whose five-year plans were "succeeding due in no small degree to American assistance." Another argument started to gain traction as well—not necessarily that the US should try to win India over, but that it should, at the very least, try to maintain the very Indian nonalignment that had previously created trouble in the US-India relationship. Representative Clement J. Zablocki (D-WI), who had led a congressional study mission to India, vocalized this sentiment, adding, "Discontinuing or stopping future assistance will only drive India further into the Soviet and Communist orbit."[307]

There was also some improvement in the interactions of policymakers on both sides. Dulles traveled to India in March 1956. While differences over issues like recognition of China remained, signs of change were evident. Nehru reiterated the need to resolve the offshore islands problem as soon as possible, but he admitted that the issue of Taiwan could be "deferred" for years. Furthermore, he acknowledged that though China was "inherently less aggressive than the Russians," given that its experience with revolution was more recent, Beijing might be "more aggressive." The tone of the